

from photography and cinema—that continue to impact us till today.

What is remarkable about her work is that while most photographers like to remain behind the camera, she is often the protagonist in hers. So, in the photograph titled 'Kali', which is part of the ongoing 'Mother India' project, she appears as the fierce Hindu goddess, whereas in 'The Arrival of Vasco da Gama', she plays her first male role as the celebrated navigator. Pushpamala believes that by becoming a part of the narrative, the meaning of the narrative automatically changes. "If I was not the central character, the meaning would be different," she states simply. ■

–Deepali Dhingra

ART WORK ▼

LETTERS AND LANDSCAPES

An exhibition at MAP, Bengaluru, explores Ram Kumar's dual identity as painter and writer

To mark the centenary of Ram Kumar—one of India's most celebrated modernists—the Museum of Art & Photography (MAP), Bengaluru, is presenting *Shape of a Thought: Letters from Ram Kumar*, on view till October 26, 2025. This exhibition pairs Kumar's contemplative abstract canvases with personal letters, inviting visitors to pause, reflect and experience his work beyond traditional interpretation.

Curated by Arnika Ahldag, director, curation & exhibition, and Priya Chauhan, associate curator, the exhibition explores Kumar's identity as painter and writer. Rather than treating abstraction as a problem to solve, the exhibition encourages viewers to dwell in the space between image and text—where feelings, ideas, and memories intersect.

"Ram Kumar was not only a painter but also a deeply expressive writer. He stayed in close touch with friends through letters: vivid, introspective pieces of writing that reveal his emotional world," says Ahldag. "In this exhibition, we paired his writings with paintings by searching for resonances between a feeling captured in a phrase and the mood of a canvas."

Ram Kumar's journey into art was unplanned. Born in Simla in 1924, he initially studied economics and wrote short stories. After enrolling in art classes at the Sarada Ukil School in Delhi, he studied in Paris under André Lhote and Fernand Léger. His works depict barren landscapes and abstract cityscapes, evoking solitude, alienation and existential reflection. "Ram Kumar believed that art should be felt, not explained," Ahldag continues. "We've tried to honour that by offering gentle ways in: through quotes, personal writings and open-ended questions that invite contemplation rather than dictate meaning."

For MAP, the exhibition furthers a mission of accessibility and emotional connection. Founder Abhishek Poddar explains, "Abstract art can often feel intimidating. With *Shape of a Thought*, we wanted to counter that idea. Ram Kumar was a storyteller. Long before he began painting, he wrote. Some of his books are on display too, his letters are excerpted throughout, and it invites visitors to see his art as a continuation of that impulse to express." ■

—Nikhil Sardana



MELANCHOLY ON CANVAS
Clockwise, Ram Kumar, 'Benaras' (1960), Untitled (1970)



